Grounded in Place: Teaching Research Through Local Engagement

CCCC Fall Virtual Institute 2025

Wren Bouwman

IOWA STATE UNIVERSITY

How I Got Here

5 years of teaching intermediate composition courses

Choosing Generic Research Topics

Difficulty Applying "Reasoning"

Increasing Use of Generative A.I.

What I Did

Original Unit:

- 1750+ Word Synthesis Essay
- 5+ Sources
- 1 Required Image

- Required Interview or Observation
- Application of Community Capital Framework

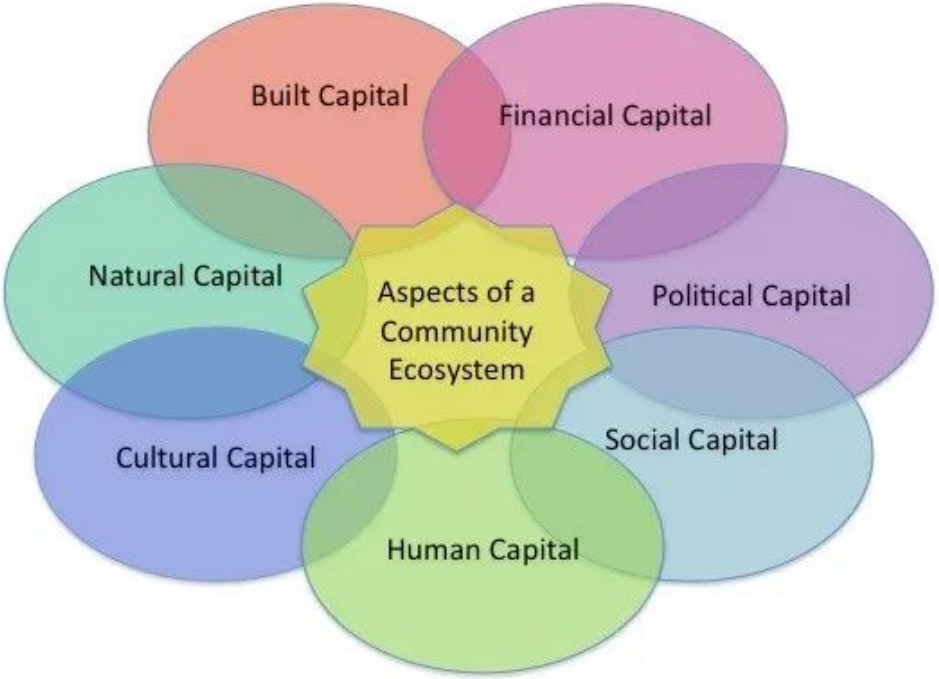
What I Did

Three new lecture points and learning activities:

- Designing Interview Questions
- Community Capitals Framework
- Interview/Observation Notes

Week	Tasks
1: Introducing the Assignment	• Topic Proposal • Potential Sources
2: Finding Evidence	• Interview Questions • CCF Worksheet
3: Crafting an Argument	• CER Worksheet • Sample Paragraphs
4: Conducting Local Research	• Interview/Observation
5: Editing and Peer Review	• Peer Review • Final Draft

Community Capitals Framework



Source: Community Capitals Framework & Sustainable Communities,
Cornelia Butler Flora, Rural Studies Research Seminar, July 4, 2006, University of Guelph

- Group work with examples of each capital
- Guided Group Reading
- Individual Work

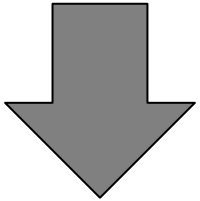
Conducting Interviews

Optional: Submit a draft of your email requesting an interview for feedback

1. Identify Focus of Interview
2. Identify What you Want to Know
3. Ask Open-Ended Questions
    a. descriptive (“What’s happening?”)
    b. interpretive (“Why is it happening?”)
    c. reflective (“How do you think it could change?”)

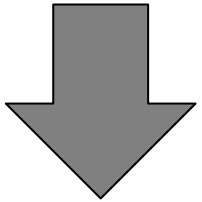
How it went

Choosing Generic Research Topics



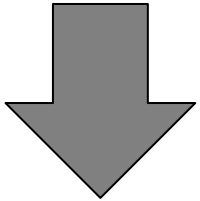
Students chose personal topics

Difficulty Applying "Reasoning"



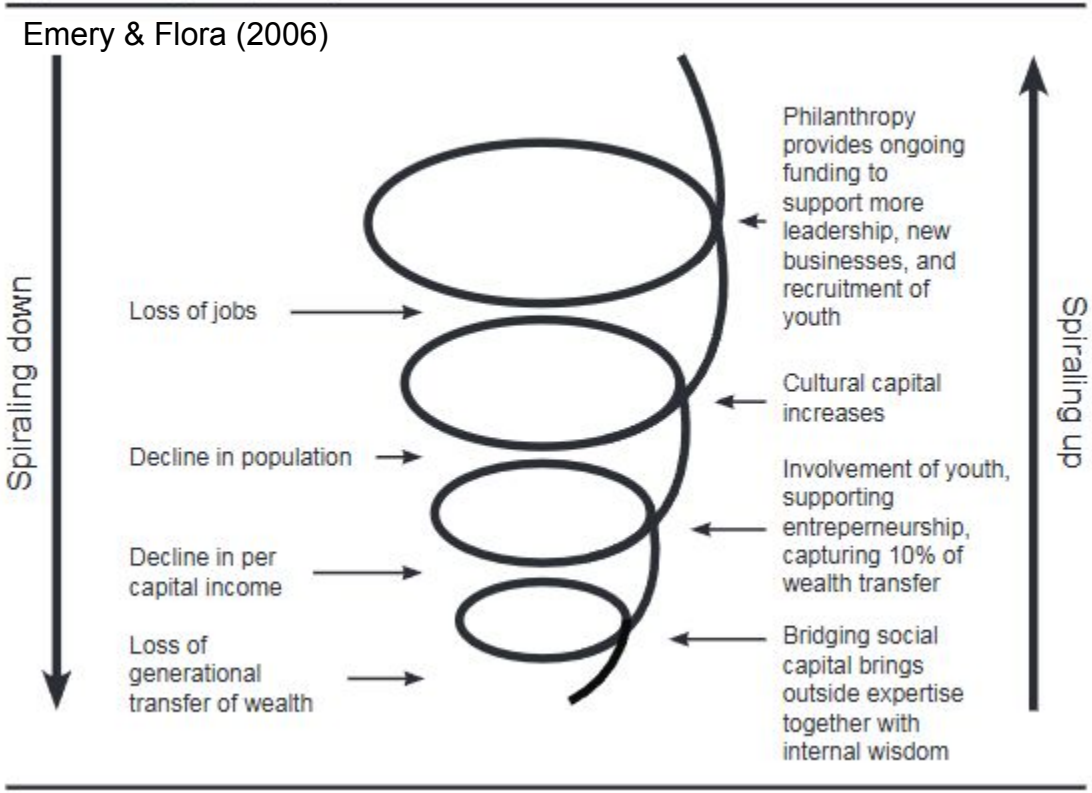
Students referenced capitals

Increasing Use of Generative A.I.



Students had shared language

What I'd do differently



- Incorporate CCF earlier and continue it longer
  - Rhetorical Analysis with CCF
  - Multimodal Design aimed at Spiraling Up
- Teach Spiraling Up/Down without reading
- Interactive/scaffolded activities for interview questions

Continued Collaboration

Wren Bouwman
Ph.D. Candidate

bouwman.wren@gmail.com
bouwman@iastate.edu

At this link, you can find:

- This presentation
- Lesson Plans
- Slide decks
- Student Samples (coming soon)

thewrenegade.github.io/portfolio/cccc-fvi / bit.ly/4ogaf2g